

Einstein with his wife, Mileva, and their son Hans Albert, ca. 1904.
[courtesy Schweizerisches Literaturachiv/Archiv der Einstein-Gesellschaft, Bern.]

Einstein's Relative Space and Time, and Absolute Speed of Light

Michele Angelo Besso was especially helpful in May 1905, when Einstein, after focusing for several years on other physics issues, returned to Maxwell's electrodynamic laws and their tantalizing hints of length contraction and time dilation. Einstein's search for some way to make sense of these hints was impeded by a mental block. To clear the block, he sought help from Besso. As he recalled later, "That was a very beautiful day when I visited [BessoJ and began to talk with him as follows: 'I have recently had a question which was difficult for me to understand. So I came here today to bring with me a battle on the question.' Trying a lot of discussions with him, I could suddenly comprehend the matter. The next day I visited him again and said to him without greeting: 'Thank you. I've completely solved the problem.'"